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Culture (OWC): [Mbuti \(FO04\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Central Africa

Field Date: 1970-1973 (P. Viii)

Coverage Date: Ca. 1876-1960

Place Coverage: Not Specified

Section Title(S): NOMADISM AND MOBILITY

Yet with all this mockery and ridicule, and very real trickery, there was never a trace of malice or real hostility. If anything, it was really rather friendly ridicule, a form of group joking relationship that merely helped to establish the clear and necessary difference between "them" and "us." Simple preference marked the essential difference, rather than any sense of superiority or inferiority.

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As it happened, I loved the cool and dim light of the forest and the high humidity did not bother me at all; it was much less oppressive than the heat and dust of the village. And whereas the water in the villages tended to be contaminated enough to give me stomach disorders, I could drink from any forest stream with impunity. Above all, in the forest there were no mosquitos or flies, except high up in the canopy or along the banks of the wider rivers. My obvious pleasure in being away from the village, and the fact that, through stupidity rather than bravery, I was totally unafraid, quickly classified me as a "forest person" rather than a "villager."

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That was fine by me, but it plainly colored my field work, giving me much greater access to the lives and thoughts and dreams of the Mbuti than I could otherwise ever have had, but at the same time denying me equal access to the world of the villagers, who came to regard me with the same kind of rather amused disdain that they had, or pretended to have, for the Mbuti. Once, proud of having learned one of their languages (KiBira) from the Mbuti, I tried it out in a Bira village. But they said (somewhat contemptuously) they had a hard time understanding me because I spoke "just like an Mbuti." To some extent I was always excluded from the inner world of the villagers. But then, any fieldworker is limited by many things--by his or her gender, age, marital

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status, food preferences, stamina, and health. The best we can do is to accept those limitations knowingly, take whatever corrective action is possible, and not pretend to omniscience.

During all those first three field trips, during the colonial era, I fell into the same role as a classificatory Mbuti, and spent my time with them whether they were in village or forest. They seldom stayed in the village for more than a few days at any one time, and the deeper they went into the forest the longer they stayed away, though in the Epulu region, where I mostly worked, the village was never more than a fast three-days walk away.

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Some anthropologists, most in fact, have held that the Epulu band was not typical, partly because of the presence of Patrick Putnam. He had come to do his field work there, but had stayed and established a hospital and a kind of hotel for the rare travelers who, in those early days, ventured along that dreadful road linking Stanleyville (as it was still called) to Bunia and the roads south. Later the colonial government established an animal-capturing station at Epulu, and it was alleged that this made the Mbuti of the Epulu territory still further atypical. There is some truth to this argument, and we shall look at it later. But for the moment I shall simply repeat, with the advantage of hindsight, what I said then, namely, that in most essential respects I found little difference between the Epulu Mbuti and any other net-hunting Mbuti *in the forest world*. I think many, though not all, differences  33 of opinion are due to the changes that have taken place in the years that intervened between the fifties and the seventies. But for the purist, and as a matter of simple fact, let us take what follows as representative at least, if not only, of the Epulu band.

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